

Research Study Proposal:

The Effect of Documentary Film on Library Stakeholders' Impression of Librarianship

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Topic Under Investigation & Purpose of Study

The topic under investigation is whether the 2025 documentary film *The Librarians* has any effect on library stakeholders' impression of librarianship within the context of the professional and personal fallout censorship has on librarians. There is a gap in the literature around how library stakeholders feel about the increased frequency of mistreatment of librarians related to book challenges and bans. Do stakeholders feel that recent news stories concerning the harassment, investigation, termination, forced resignation, online threats, personal attacks, suits, and smear campaigns against librarians are appropriate responses to disagreements about the materials found within libraries? Do stakeholders want librarians to be treated with professional dignity? Do they align more so with recent legislative policies that attempt to criminalize librarians? Or is there greater depth and nuance to how stakeholders view librarianship within the context of censorship? Yeon and Dudak (2025) explain that:

Library workers are defending against book banning in larger numbers, and their very work is coming into public scrutiny and questioning. In such stressful times, the potential for trauma from the library workplace is higher and more charged... This issue demands a call for action. It is imperative that we direct more attention to the library staff and community members affected by material challenges and censorship. Their mental and physical well-being should be at the forefront of our consideration.

This study is a response to the above call for action. It will measure the effect of the film on stakeholders' impressions of librarianship in the context of book censorship, book challenges, and book bans. The initial qualitative phase will explore the topic of mistreatment of librarians within the bounds of the Liberty Hill Independent School District (LHISD). LHISD is in Williamson County, which, over the last decade, has experienced a political shift from reliably conservative voting patterns to slightly liberal-leaning results and is now a competitive "purple" area. The county has a long history of entertaining

administrative book censorship activities, but review committees often retain the materials that have been challenged. Additionally, the researcher is unaware of any LHISD librarians being placed on administrative leave or being fired for maintaining access to challenged books. However, many stakeholders at LHISD are aware of news stories in bordering and nearby districts where librarians have been negatively impacted by censorship related issues. It is the researcher's assumption that this mix of characteristics may yield rich qualitative data.

Additionally, the greater purpose of this study is to use its findings to design a scalable pilot program that librarians can use to stimulate local conversation around their being mistreated in connection with book challenges that arise in their own communities. Bringing attention to the fallout censorship creates can be done in an ethical, well-researched manner that has been shown to improve community relations. Many anti-censorship resources, training programs, and financial supports for librarians already exist but this study aims to specifically address the issue of mistreatment of librarians rather than only the issues of censorship, book challenges, or book bans. This study aims to eventually give librarians a solid tool to inform stakeholders of the professional impacts book bans have, allow them to open a discourse within their community, and help them advocate for their own well-being.

Theoretical or Philosophical Perspective

A social psychology framework called Social Identity Theory (SIT) and Brenda Dervin's Sense Making Theory from the fields of communication and library and information science both inform the proposed study. The mistreatment of librarians is a complex social issue which could be interpreted through SIT. The theory was developed by Henri Tajfel, a social psychologist whose work sought to explain the "ingroup/outgroup" dynamic where people naturally classify themselves into social groups, intertwine their identities with group identities, and then compare the characteristics of their "ingroups" with the contradictory characteristics of others in "outgroups" who maintain alternate identities. When

considering the components of SIT in the context of the mistreatment of librarians as the result of diverse perspectives on book censorship, a potential explanation can be discerned. If one considers themselves a part of the ingroup that strongly opposes students learning about racism, LGBTQ+ issues, and sex, then they may view librarians as representative of the outgroup rather than viewing librarians as close community members deserving of socially inclusive engagement despite disagreement.

Sense Making Theory follows directly and informs the approach of the proposed study. The theory was developed by Brenda Dervin, a leading figure in communication and information science research whose work placed value on the diverse themes that are often found in the dialogic data that is collected during anthropocentric research in order to bridge informational gaps. Embracing the diverse perspectives of the participants in this study would allow the researcher to navigate any dynamic “ingroup/outgroup” tensions experienced during a focus group and allow community members to explore making sense of the issue of the mistreatment of librarians despite their differences rather than forcing one side or the other to concede or simply wishing the opposition would change their minds or adjust their behavior. In other words, Dervin’s communications approach would focus on opening a dialogue that welcomes data from opposing viewpoints to be considered in a program design that is accepting of difference and asks, “where do we go from here?” After considering Sense Making, it was clear that a quantitative approach alone would not be sufficient in measuring any changes in stakeholders’ impressions using the film as an intermediary. In considering the current tensions around issues of censorship and the complexity of balancing polarities, it was clear that the addition of a dialogic qualitative approach could help to uncover additional, useful data.

Research Question

The research question is: what effect does watching the 2025 documentary film *The Librarians* have on library stakeholders’ impression of librarianship in the context of book censorship in the Liberty

Hill Independent School District? In this study, the term “stakeholders” will refer to study participants drawn from a pool of LHISD parents/guardians, school librarians, school administrators, schoolteachers, and school board members. The phrase “impression of librarianship” will refer to the study’s pre/post-film screening findings about participants’ feelings and judgements towards librarianship in the context of book censorship. The phrase “book censorship” will refer to book challenges, book bans, and collection development policies that restrict access to books.

Research Design

The proposed study will utilize an exploratory sequential mixed methods approach. A small qualitative instrumental case study (Part I) will lead to a larger, one-group pretest-posttest quantitative study (Part II). This approach aligns with the researcher’s idea to explore social identity as a factor in the mistreatment of librarians by engaging participants in dialogue. The depth of qualitative data gathered will be analyzed to make any needed adjustments to the larger survey instrument. Both sets of data will then be triangulated (Part III) to answer the research question more fully by combining the contextual understanding from the qualitative data with the numerical insights of the quantitative data.

The research will begin with an invitation to participate in the study. All LHISD librarians, schoolteachers, school administrators, and school board members will be contacted via the email addresses provided on the district’s websites. Parents and guardians will be invited to participate via social media pages affiliated with various district related parental groups. Platform-specific searches for the school district’s name and the individual school names plus common terms such as “PTO” and “parent” will be used to locate a variety of parental groups to include parent-teacher organizations, sports/arts/STEM boosters, special education resource groups, and meetup groups. A Google Form that outlines the purpose of the research, the expected time commitment from participants, a confidentiality statement, a voluntary participation and withdrawal statement, an informed consent statement, a

response deadline, and a request for contact details will be utilized to collect voluntary responses. The Google Form will collect responses for two weeks. Then, a nested and disproportional stratified random sample will be used to select two stakeholders from each stratum (two librarians, two schoolteachers, two administrators, two board members, and two parents).

On LHISD's About webpage, their vision statement is stated as "building champions in academics, character, and community." My strategy for getting survey participants to agree to take part in this research will leverage two of the three aspects of that vision statement: character and community. Personalized requests to the smaller strata (librarians, administrators, and school board members) will outline the importance of this research as a tool that will be used to improve character in how we treat librarians and to improve community relations by building and maintaining trust in district librarians. For the larger strata (teachers and parents/guardians), the value of the survey to the school community as a whole will be advertised in a similar manner.

Part I

The random sample of 10 participants will be asked to attend a licensed screening of the documentary film at a reserved LHISD community room equipped with a projector. The participants will be asked to take personal notes on any of the aspects of the film they have reactions to, feel strongly about, are inspired by, or have questions about. Following the screening, the participants will be sent a Google Form survey via email containing open-ended questions about their impressions of the librarians in the film, the themes of the film, and how the film relates to their personal experiences with LHISD libraries. Responses to these questions will be analyzed to identify any reoccurring themes. This thematic code will be used to create guided focus group questions for the second phase of the qualitative portion of the study. In this focus group, participants will discuss the themes of the film with one another. This dialogue will be recorded with their permission and will also be analyzed to identify themes. There are

several community centers in the area that offer rooms reservations for free to the public for this phase. The dates for each phase of Part I will be shared with participants in advance.

Part II

To begin the quantitative phase of the design, the themes identified in the survey entries and the analysis of the focus group dialogue will be used to create a quantitative survey instrument. Subjects from the original stratified random sample (minus the 10 focus group participants) will be notified that there are three phases to their participation. They will first receive a google form pretest survey via email which they will have two weeks to complete. The pretest survey will then be disabled at a pre-determined and advertised date. Participants who respond to the pretest survey will be assigned a unique identifier to track their participation and will be asked to watch the documentary film on their own using the free PBS app streaming platform or online via PBSs Independent Lens. Access instructions will be sent to each participant via email. This email will contain a statement detailing the expectation that the film be viewed in its entirety and requesting that participants respond via email once they've viewed the film. Participants who respond will be sent a posttest survey via email again utilizing Google Forms.

The data gathered in the surveys mentioned above will include a series of Likert-scale questions arranged into thematic sections. The sections will be organized as follows:

- Pretest background and demographics concerning each participant's current role or connection to LHISD, prior exposure to the topic, and library engagement level. This information will only be used in relation to the statistical analysis of participants' individual impressions of librarianship

- Pre/posttest core impressions of the profession of librarianship, the mistreatment of librarians, and censorship related activities
- Pre/posttest knowledge around the issue of book banning, current view on librarians who oppose book bans, and the negative impacts of censorship on librarians
- The posttest survey will begin with a manipulation check (a few multiple-choice questions about the central purpose of the film, the primary protagonists, and a memorable visual element)
- Posttest reactions to *The Librarians* documentary film, its emotional impact (the feelings and judgements that inform one's impressions can come from the conscious interpretation of an emotion), the credibility of the information shared in the film, its impact on prior beliefs, its impact on level of support toward librarians who oppose censorship, and an open-ended question about any parts of the film that stood out
- Posttest self-reported changes in overall impressions of librarianship, likelihood of future participation in active support for libraries/librarians, perception of libraries as necessary institutions
- Posttest opportunity for open-ended reflection

Part III

A statistical analysis of pretest-posttest impression shifts toward the mistreatment of librarians and the library profession will be performed and triangulated with the earlier qualitative findings. If this analysis is informative, it will be used to create a community-based pilot program that helps librarians use the film in their own settings to create local dialogue around the mistreatment of librarians.

Ethical Considerations

The values that inform this research study include the importance of addressing societal injustices; the protection of the First Amendment and the idea of intellectual freedom; the creation of knowledge that hinders the oppression of minority groups; and the amplification of democratic voices. Librarians have recently been stigmatized as “groomers” and “child abusers” so their participation in this study is crucial. In terms of design, some of the ethics protocols that will govern this study, such as the inclusion of confidentiality, voluntary participation and withdrawal, and informed consent statements, have been discussed above but additionally it will be important to use politically sensitive and culturally competent terminology in the focus group questions, the survey instrument, and in the resulting documentation.

To be transparent about potential privacy concerns, participants in Part I of the study will receive information about how their identities will be known to one another as they will take part in a focus group. However, they will also be informed that their identities will not be used in any publications, and their identifying information will be disposed of following the assignment of unique aliases to help track their input. Participants in Part II of the study will enjoy a higher level of anonymity in that they will not be known to one another and will be assigned unique identifiers to track their survey responses. All participants will be informed about the purpose of the study (to bring awareness to the importance of ensuring the physical and mental well-being of district librarians) prior to their participation.

The researcher will seek to decrease bias by increasing linguistic clarity and mutual intelligibility in partial collaboration with the subjects of the study by using the qualitative phase data to improve the quantitative survey questions. The results of the study will be shared with all participants prior to publication and differing perspectives in the data will be reported. Before beginning the study, the researcher will contact the IRB for permission to conduct the study and will consult with the IRB about

any changes that need to be made in the research design. Additionally, any known risks to participants will be shared prior to their participation. For instance, librarians may feel distress talking about their experiences with book challenges, especially in front of administrators and school board members. This may limit the amount they are willing to share in a focus group. Therefore, focus group participants will receive information about the ground rules around active listening and respect without judgement for focus group discussion. They will also be told that while the intent is for the focus group to remain cordial, the social aspects of this issue may lead to unanticipated experiences. Following the completion of the study, all participants will be thanked via email for their involvement. Finally, participants will be informed that the research results will be submitted to an appropriate LIS journal for publication and may be presented at an LIS conference.

References

- Yeon, J., & Dudak, L. T. (2025). Potential for trauma in public libraries experiencing book banning and material challenges. *Public Library Quarterly*, 44(5), 539–563.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/01616846.2024.2442215>